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INDIA'S "NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST" POLICY AND THE CHINESE CHALLENGE

The cases of Bangladesh, Nepal, and Sri Lanka

S. D. Muni

Neighbourhood relations are delicate and difficult, as proximity breeds comfort and compulsions as well as contempt, more so in the case of a country like India, where most of the neighbours are tied in what may be called a civilisational relationship. Some of them were even parts of India. India has often endeavoured to recreate a community out of such a neighbourhood, though without much success. To that end, Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched his "neighbourhood first" policy as soon as he assumed office in May 2014, with considerable enthusiasm and fanfare. This policy has yielded only partial results. The challenges faced by this policy have been diverse and numerous, as they relate not only to failures and inadequacies in India's own approach but also to political turbulence in the